

Getting started

When I tell people what I do for a living, most assume that I *must* be an engineer. My geekiness does not help dispel that notion of course, but the fact is I studied business in college. And having done that, like most of my batchmates, I thought I was either destined to be a suit or to start 'something of my own'.

Quite a few of us were extremely gung ho about the idea of starting our own business. Our college curriculum even had a course on that subject for glob's sake – yes, we studied entrepreneurship. Students, especially from colleges like mine that were more focussed on the liberal arts, were literally infected by the idea that passions *have* to be pursued. Profits would naturally follow.

This was the year 2006 and somehow, we didn't refer to these endeavours in entrepreneurship as startups. At least the term wasn't as popular and ubiquitous as it is today. We'd say "business ideas" or refer to them as "ventures".

Either way, I did conceive one such "venture" and even executed it. It was a learning experience and if you bear with me, I'd like to share a wee bit of wisdom with you. Before that though, let me tell you why what I established was a "startup" (in the sense of what the word has come to mean today), and not a traditional business.

To start with (no pun intended), it was a tech-based initiative. The website that I launched aimed to streamline the admission process of Mumbai colleges. With literally hundreds of colleges in the city, students had to endure Mumbai's punishing rains, first to fill out admission forms, and then to physically go and check whether their names had appeared on admission lists. This list checking process had to be repeated more often than not, because any given college could release as many as four merit lists. This seems so futile in today's day and age, right? But, that's what was done back then. I was passionate about the idea and it had all the right ingredients for a good startup – a good idea, technology as the backbone, a burning need, a large user base, and scalability.

But it failed.

For this startup, I had the support of a few of my batchmates. Having endured the admissions ordeal themselves only a few months before, they were easily sold on the idea. We decided to approach the problem at the source – the colleges themselves. We went to about 30 of the best colleges (which probably got 90 percent of the applications anyway) and tried to convince the principals to put up the admission lists on our website. Being a frequenter of forums, I decided that the quickest way to do this would be by installing a forum, creating admin logins for colleges, and allowing them to upload their lists themselves.

The colleges refused. We suspected they weren't comfortable with the transparency we would inadvertently bring about.

If this was present day, and had the colleges refused, their reluctance to come on board would seem almost idiotic considering the technology available at our disposal. Most students today have high-res cameras in their pockets, and sharing those lists online would be just a click and tap away.

The idea would've sailed through to success quite easily.

The point I'm trying to make is that startups weren't easy – especially a few years ago, because the kind of technology ecosystem we have today was lacking. Capital was scarce and the idea of "dotcoms" still raised a few eyebrows.

Today, things are different. E-commerce is a reality; the Flipkart-isation of the country has begun. Most importantly, the primordial soup consisting of venture capital, userbase and talent is there. All you need is that one spark and your story will begin.

Get out there. Start something. 



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"Students, especially from colleges like mine that were more focussed on the liberal arts, were literally infected by the idea that passions *have* to be pursued. Profits would naturally follow."

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

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